Soviet missile., they agreed that the response would have to be limited to that particular site, not broadened to an attack on all Soviet installations in Cuba. Turning to Germany, they decided against suspending the usual traffic between Western Germany and Berlin. After the end of the session, President Kennedy called General Lucius Clay, a veteran troubleshooter but also a troublemaker in West Berlin. The general sounded ready to serve his country in what had arguably again become the most dangerous place on earth. He told the president: “I am available anytime for anything.”[4]

The most urgent matter on the ExCom agenda that day was the implementation of the naval blockade. By 6:00 p.m., when the ExCom met for its evening session, there was good news from the Organization of American States (OAS), which had approved the blockade unanimously. It was an unexpected result, as there had been concern that even two-thirds would not be easy to get. They could now move ahead with the formal declaration of the blockade, but first they had to decide what to do with Soviet ships in the Atlantic. ExCom agreed that those on the way to Cuba should be stopped, but what were they to do with those that turned back? Let them go undisturbed, or intercept them? John Kennedy believed that the ships should not be stopped, but he found it difficult to convince his brother of his approach.

Robert Kennedy was a late arrival to the blockade camp and saw it as a prelude to a military strike against Cuba. Now he saw the blockade as an opportunity to stop and search any Soviet ship in hopes of uncovering evidence that it was delivering offensive weapons to Cuba. “It would be a hell of an advantage to be able to come in and have pictures of the missiles,” he told the gathering. “And also, I would raise the point that there possibly would be an intelligence advantage to be able to examine some materials.” He wanted to establish a zone within which all ships would be stopped and searched, no matter which way they were going. He had a cover story ready for such action: “Say you don’t know, when they turn around, whether they’re going to try to come into Cuba in a different fashion.”[5]

John Kennedy was not impressed. He believed that the Soviets would turn back ships transporting weapons, so that the search would produce nothing but an international scandal. He was also unsure at what distance